



long legs and claws
for climbing

long, narrow tail
aids swimming

Australian water dragon

Intellagama lesueurii

True to its name, this large lizard frequents many flowing freshwater habitats, from cool upland streams to city rivers, and even occasional estuaries. It is a proficient swimmer and also a capable climber.

Basking then hunting

The water dragon basks on rocks (or a road or patio) until it is warm enough to hunt—in trees, on the ground, and along the water's edge. It searches for snails and crabs as well as small vertebrates such as frogs and chicks. In some locations, however, fruit

and vegetation comprise up to half of its diet. To avoid danger, the water dragon races up a tree or dives underwater, where it can stay submerged for more than an hour. In winter, water dragons living to the south of their range hide in a burrow, or among roots or rocks, and brumate (similar to hibernation); in the north, they remain active all year. In spring, territorial males display to rivals and to attract females with much head-bobbing, tail-flicking, and leg-flourishing. Hatchlings mainly eat insects until they are about half grown.

- ↔ 3 ft (1m)
- ⚖ 2–3 lb (1–1.4 kg)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🍷 Small animals, fruit, plants



E. Australia

large tympanum
(external eardrum)



◁ SNUB-NOSED PROFILE

The short, deep snout and angular head is accentuated by a central crest of scales that runs from head to tail, enlarging considerably from the neck rearward.